

# What psychological support actually involves

What to expect from working with a psychologist for a gut–brain condition — demystified.

Being referred to a psychologist for a gut condition can feel confusing — or even like your symptoms aren't being taken seriously. In fact, it's the opposite. It reflects how much the gut and brain influence each other, and how effective gut–brain psychological therapies are.

## It's not “it's all in your head”

Your symptoms are real and physical. Psychological support works with the nervous system and the patterns around symptoms — it never assumes you're imagining them.

## What sessions look like

- **Understanding your patterns** — how symptoms, stress, attention and daily life interact for you.
- **Building practical tools** — regulation skills, ways to work with hypervigilance, and steadier routines.
- **Values-based action** — reclaiming the activities and life that matter, at a pace that lasts.

## Evidence-based approaches

Depending on what fits, this may draw on cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT), acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), compassion-focused therapy (CFT), gut-directed clinical hypnotherapy, and motivational interviewing — all with strong evidence for disorders of gut–brain interaction.

## Practical points

- **Alongside medical care.** Psychological support complements your gastroenterology and GP care — it doesn't replace it.
- **In person or telehealth.** You can take part from wherever you are.
- **Confidential.** Sessions are private; brief updates are shared with your team only with your consent.

You can begin with a short, confidential intake — and if you'd like to get oriented first, the Capacity Check helps point you to the right level of support.

This sheet is general information — not a diagnosis or a substitute for medical care. EF Health psychological support works alongside your medical team, never instead of it. If your symptoms are new, severe, or changing, please speak with your GP or specialist.

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